

Action plan 2024-2028

Organisation	The South-Eastern Finland University of Applied Sciences, Xamk
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Core commitments of CoARA

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

Research, development, and researcher assessment at Xamk is, besides COARA, based on the following national commitments:

- Good practice in researcher evaluation. Recommendation for the responsible evaluation of a researcher in Finland (2020).

- Policy for open scholarship (2022).
- The Finnish Code of Conduct for Research Integrity and Procedures for Handling Alleged Violations of Research Integrity in Finland (2023).

1. Research activities at Xamk

According to the Universities of Applied Sciences Act, one of the missions of universities of applied sciences is “to carry out applied research, development and innovation activities and artistic activities that serve education in universities of applied sciences, promote industry, business and regional development and regenerate the industrial structure of the region”. These are commonly referred to as RDI activities.

RDI refers to systematic activities aimed at increasing knowledge about a certain topic and using this knowledge to discover new applications. Research, and applied research, in particular, is part of Xamk’s RDI activities. RDI activities include, for example, externally funded development and research projects that promote industry, business, and regional development as well as systematic, evaluated, and public action that serves education in universities of applied sciences, such as the production of open educational resources. Education-related RDI activities also include theses and study attainments resulting from internal or externally funded projects or commissions to develop or study industry and business with the purpose of creating something significantly new.

Our RDI activities aim to have a lasting positive impact by, in particular, increasing the vitality of South-Eastern Finland. These activities are conducted in networks and ecosystems, and in close cooperation with industry and businesses. The RDI activities of the South-Eastern Finland University of Applied Sciences create new knowledge, solutions, methods, products, and services for the needs of the region and society. We promote our societal impact through scientific, professional, and artistic publications and general communication.

Responsible assessment applies not only to researchers but also to all RDI actors at Xamk. This refers to persons who, either partly or entirely in their work, engage in development or research work, production of educational resources, or other systematic professional development by, for example, publishing scientific, professional, and artistic publications based on research, reviews, experiments, or good practices and participating in professional networks that promote education in universities of applied sciences, regional development, and the industrial structure of the region. Our RDI actors are experts in creating new knowledge and work in many different positions here.

2. Objectives

Together with the reform of responsible research assessment, we aim to improve and bring forward the strengths and characteristics of our RDI work and recognise and acknowledge the diversity of research and development work as part of research assessment.

Xamk aims to increase the transparency and fairness of the assessment of RDI activities and actors, and pay more attention to diverse research and development activities and outputs and the quality and impact of RDI work.

We aim to

1. assess only when necessary;
2. make visible the practices and matters considered in the assessment
3. support staff career development in different RDI positions;
4. actively involve the assessed party in the assessment;
5. develop a transparent, fair, and credible assessment procedure for professional publications;
6. further increase the diversity of Xamk's research and development work as well as its role in the development of the region, industry and business;
7. establish ourselves as an attractive employer and responsible research organisation.

3. Current situation

Recognising the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, RDI, is natural within our context. Our RDI is diverse and values the impact we create. In recent years, we have invested in renewing how we measure our RDI impact, emphasising the diverse contributions to research and development, such as start-ups, new business concepts, partners, media exposure, and RDI study credits.

Xamk has established a Researcher's Career Path. This is the first step in identifying and defining the common issues to be considered in research assessment. This assessment is based on the diversity of contributions and activities of a researcher, for example, project activities, guidance, teaching, publishing, evaluation work, and working life connections. It includes both qualitative assessment and peer review.

Journal and publication-based metrics are only one aspect of assessing Xamk's RDI activities. The prestige of a publication is not especially relevant to career development at Xamk. Xamk awards a publication incentive to employees for their scientific and professional publications that are included in the publication data reporting to the

Ministry of Education and Culture. Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index are not used to assess RDI or RDI staff. Xamk does not use rankings in research assessment.

Many of the challenges CoARA seeks to address arise from the traditions of academic research, which are less prevalent in universities of applied sciences due to our focus on the applied nature of research.

Research and development assessment at Xamk	Assessment Elements
Organisation-wide assessments	Assessment of Quality Management system – FINEEC audit National Monitoring of Open Science and Research Strategic metrics Management Reviews
Assessment related to external funding	Ministry of Education and Culture, core funding model Assessment of project applications by RDI funders Reports to the funders
RDI	Internal assessment of project applications (RDI Management Team) Interim and final self-assessment of projects (project management system) Project impact assessment and monitoring, impact indicators (project management system) RDI Output and Impact: external funding received, publications, patents, start-ups, partners, media exposure, RDI study credits (RDI scorecard) Ethical Review
Teaching and Pedagogy	Teaching Student and thesis supervision Development of educational resources Publications Development of learning tools and methods Development of teaching methods and pedagogy Development of educational products
Researcher/RDI Staff Assessment	Recruitment Development discussions

	Researcher's Career Path
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4. Actions

Action	Main steps	Time	Responsible Party
Researcher's Career Path implementation		2024-2026	Development Services
	Researcher assessment process and criteria	2024	Development Services Researcher's Career Path Steering Group
	Reviewing and modifying the process and criteria, involving staff	2025-2026	Development Services Researcher's Career Path Steering Group
Responsible assessment as part of HR processes		2025 - 2026	HR Services
	Principles of responsible assessment in HR processes	2025	Development Services HR Services
	Updating recruitment process, if needed	2025	Development Services HR Services
	Career path and confirming RDI competence	2025-2026	Development Services HR Services
	Updating the development discussion process for staff	2025	Development Services HR Services
Involving leaders and staff in reforming assessment		2024-2028	Development Services HR Services
	Promoting the use of Research.fi service, especially expert activities.	2024-2025	Development Services

	Provide communication and guidance on responsible assessment	2025-2028	Development Services HR Services
National-level cooperation and development		2024-2028	Development Services
	CoARA National Chapter Finland CoARA working group of Finnish UAS Finnish UAS RDI Leaders Network		

5. Assessment and monitoring

The Finnish national monitoring of Open Science and Research occurs every other year. Responsible research assessment is a core part of this monitoring process.

The self-assessment of our progress is done yearly as part of the monitoring of Open Science and Research. This is conducted by Xamk's Open Science and Research working group and approved by the Management Team. The CoARA Action Plan is updated as needed as part of this process.

6. Approval and updates

Approval	Time	
Management Team	16.12.2024	
Update	Time	Approval

Implementation schedule

	2024		2025		2026		2027		2028	
Researcher's Career Path implementation										
Researcher assessment process and criteria										
Reviewing and modifying the process and criteria, involving staff										
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Principles of responsible assessment in HR processes										
Updating recruitment process, if needed										
Career path and confirming RDI competence										
Updating the development discussion process for staff										
Involving leaders and staff in reforming assessment										
Promoting the use of Research.fi service, especially expert activities										
Provide communication and guidance on responsible assessment										
National-level cooperation and development										

